





GIRL POWER
(clockwise from left) Amariah Awantaye and Masaba Gupta in Season 2 of *Masaba Masaba*; Vivek Gomber and Shahana Goswami in *Bombay Begums*; a still from *Four More Shots Please!*

to tread. In her feature directorial debut *Gippy*, the interval comes when the teenage heroine has her first period. In the short *Khujli*, starring Neena Gupta and Jackie Shroff, she explored a middle-aged wife's desires. Her inspiration? Her mum's request for an uncensored copy of the Hollywood film *Fifty Shades of Grey* after reading the book. For Nair, streaming has become the great enabler, empowering creators to say things sans



"OTT platforms have opened the door for more inclusive storytelling that provides greater opportunities to women"
APARNA PUROHIT
Head, India Originals, Amazon Prime Video

women writer's room felt that they could bring up issues related to women's sexual life. Season one ended with Masaba's character having a pregnancy scare. Early on in season two, Neena Gupta reprimands her daughter for not being cautious. "*Badnaami se nahin toh bimaari se daro* [If not infamy, at least fear disease]," she says, after learning that Masaba isn't sure who the father is. Later, as Masaba prioritises her career and gives relationships a break, she decides she'll have a child someday—hence the egg freezing.

Masaba Masaba is not the first time Nair ventured into territory where few dare reservations. "There's a bolder streak to it," says Nair. "Unlike films that need to cater to the widest mass possible, the show doesn't have to."

THE INCLUSIVE PUSH

A lot of the sexual liberation, especially from women's perspective, is because the writers and directors are also women. In a recent report *O Womaniya*, on women's representation in the entertainment industry, an analysis of 150 theatrical and streaming films and series released in 2021 across eight Indian languages found that OTT platforms